the ancient alphabet been lost ... The first I managed to decipher was No. 26, and this gave me the key.’[10]

Rice’s Inscription No. 1 proved to be the oldest of the inscriptions and the most valuable, because it gave an account of the Jain migration south more than two thousand years earlier under the direction of their leader Bhadrabahu: ‘It states that Bhadrabahu Swami ... having foretold in Ujjayaini [Ujjain] the approach of a dreadful famine which would last twelve years, the whole *sangha* or Jain religious brotherhood forsook the northern regions and under his leadership migrated to the south ... When approaching a wild mountain called Katavapa the *rishi* felt his end drawing nigh. He therefore sent on all his followers and, remaining behind with only one disciple, performed the last rites of a *sunnyasi* and there died.’



The elaborately decorated façade of the Chandragupta Basti on the Chandragiri hill at Sravana Belgola.